

Parliament's China conundrum

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Presented by Google By NICHOLAS VINOCUR GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur, with you for the last time ahead of a break. In today's Playbook: — Mario Draghi

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur, with you for the last time ahead of a break.

In today's Playbook:

— Mario Draghi comes to Brussels — and reignites a debate on EU competitiveness.

— You're fired: Britain's EU Relations Minister Nick Thomas-Symonds packs his bags.

— Faces in the crowd: Hamish Falconer, Gianni Infantino, Hilde Vautmans, Birgitte Nygaard Markussen, Pedro Sánchez, Mika Aaltola, Wang Yi, Jens Spahn, Engin Eroglu, Paula Pinho, Andrius Kubilius, King Philippe and many more ...

Brussels Playbook Podcast: The team is off for Belgium's National Day, but you can catch up on past episodes here .

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DRIVING THE DAY

CHINA CHALLENGE: MEPs from the European Parliament's Foreign Affairs Committee head to China today, seeking to break a deadlock over the institution's approach to Beijing. The visit comes as the Socialists and Democrats push to soften a critical report on China, while rejecting allegations the group has buckled to pressure from Beijing, write Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier and Carlo Martuscelli.

Hearing the message: Adopting the draft in its current form would have "consequences," Beijing warned the Parliament, according to a non-S&D parliamentary official. MEPs from other groups accuse the S&D of listening to Beijing and trying to water down and delay the report, which is meant to set out the Parliament's position on the EU's relationship with China.

The S&D denied being leaned on by Beijing, saying it was “not aware of any warning from any Chinese official” and stressing that cooperation with China “cannot come at the expense of EU values.” Beijing didn’t respond to a request for comment.

No consensus: More than eight months after Belgian Renew MEP Hilde Vautmans drafted the report, groups have failed to agree a common position, with amendments revealing the divisions.

Mind your language: The S&D wants to delete language that says China “offers few, if any, benefits to European companies and diminishes rather than contributes to Europe’s security,” and is “distorting global markets.” Instead, it wants to describe EU-China relations as “increasingly complex and challenging.” It also proposes scrapping any reference to China as a “strategic rival” — a definition Beijing loathes.

Spanish connection: The S&D’s most influential national leader, Spain’s Pedro Sánchez, wants deeper engagement with Beijing and has visited China four times in four years, most recently in April. Spain has also welcomed Chinese investment .

Worth noting: During Parliament’s July plenary, S&D lawmakers inserted an amendment into a separate East Asia report reaffirming the EU’s One China policy, with critics viewing it as an attempt to be more accommodating to Beijing.

Self-censorship warning: “When Beijing warns of ‘consequences’ before a report is even adopted, the warning itself is the operation,” said Finnish EPP MEP Mika Aaltola. “The goal is that Parliament softens its own language in advance.” The lawmaker urged the committee to adopt the report “exactly as drafted.”

Field report: All eyes are now on the eight-member Parliament delegation, whose findings are expected to feed into the final report and shape the groups’ push to reach a compromise in the fall. The MEPs will meet Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, senior lawmakers, Chinese Communist Party officials and technology companies.

No détente: Russia’s invasion of Ukraine, human rights, economic imbalances, Indo-Pacific security and critical supply chains are on the agenda. “I do not believe we are in a phase of détente. I see rather the opposite,” delegation member Engin Eroglu told Playbook ahead of the trip.

BIG AND BREAKING

MEET BRITAIN’S EUROPE MINISTER: Hamish Falconer has been appointed as the U.K.’s new minister for European relations , as part of a government reshuffle in which Nick Thomas-Symonds was fired from the role . Falconer is former Civil Service diplomat and Middle East minister. He will serve as minister for intergovernmental relations and European relations jointly in the Cabinet Office and the Foreign Office.

NEW FRONT IN IRAN WAR: Yemen’s Iran-aligned Houthis have announced a naval blockade on Saudi Arabia, opening a potential new front against the U.S. in its war with Iran, Reuters reports . Meanwhile, Bloomberg says U.S. forces struck Iranian targets overnight, marking the 10th straight day of attacks.

BRUSSELS RESISTS PRESSURE ON CLIMATE LAWS: The European Commission is betting that the profit-hungry gas and oil industry will continue exporting into Europe next year, resisting companies’

warnings they will be forced to seek other markets unless climate laws are rewritten.

ENVOY ALERT: The EU will appoint its new special representative to Africa's troubled Sahel region later this week, with Danish diplomat Birgitte Nygaard Markussen set to take the role after a contentious process, an official confirmed to Playbook.

EUROGROUP CHAIR EYES NEW FUNDS: Greek Finance Minister Kyriakos Pierrakakis is floating a bold new way to raise money for the EU, as debate heats up over the bloc's seven-year budget: redirecting to Brussels lucrative proceeds from national spectrum auctions.

WINDOW OF OPPORTUNITY: The resignation Jens Spahn has removed a prominent rival of Friedrich Merz while offering the chancellor the chance of a government reset ahead of crucial regional elections in the fall.

THE REPORT ON DRAGHI

CAN EUROPE GET COMPETITIVE? A lunch between Mario Draghi and Ursula von der Leyen is putting a spotlight squarely onto how well — or how poorly — the EU is doing to bolster its economy, just as the war in the Strait of Hormuz threatens to reignite a global energy crisis.

Keeping score: It's been 22 months since the former ECB chief published his report calling for sweeping reforms to modernize and strengthen Europe's economy. According to a report by French think tank Institut Montaigne, 30 percent of Draghi's recommendations have been carried out. But there's still a long way to go and von der Leyen's economic record is a hot topic, politically speaking.

Right on cue: Valérie Hayer, head of the Renew Europe group, told Max Giera that progress on implementing the report was "far too little, far too slow," adding that only one in six of Draghi's recommendations had been implemented (that's below the Institut Montaigne's count and likely refers to this EPIC count). "It is high time to complete the single market by removing the barriers that still fragment our economy," Hayer added.

Why now? Competitiveness ministers are meeting in Dublin today and the Irish EU presidency has flagged economic reforms as a priority. The EU's economy is struggling amid the Iran war, Chinese overcapacity and an AI boom happening ... elsewhere.

Step by step: The EU is making "steady progress" toward implementing the Draghi report's recommendations, Commission chief spokesperson Paula Pinho told reporters Monday, emphasizing wins on trade and simplification of EU rules. She pointed to the EU's One Europe, One Market roadmap, a work plan for all three EU institutions that flags end-2027 as the target for completing competitiveness reforms.

Post-lunch talk: Pinho said Draghi and von der Leyen had gone on to discuss "the barriers that are being actively tackled across the economy, and our ongoing work notably on innovation in AI and clean tech."

Weaker: A look at the One Europe tracker shows gaps in progress between simplification and trade legislation (29 percent and 50 percent completed respectively) versus other areas like "integrated market," in which 5 percent has been implemented, with 95 percent "planned" or "pending approval."

Numbers, shnumbers: An EU official, granted anonymity because they are not authorized to speak publicly, played down the Draghi numbers game. The official pointed to a Commission proposal for a €409 billion competitiveness fund in the next MFF, as well as defense industry programs, as issues not captured in scorecards.

Elephant in the room: EU capitals are reluctant to implement many aspects of the reform. For example, EU Inc. — a proposal to harmonize corporate legal regimes across 27 countries — has been substantially watered down from its original concept due to national objections.

The bottom line: Time is running short to carry out Draghi's vision — even incompletely. Pressure is now on the Irish presidency to rally EU capitals behind his ideas.

****Virtual briefing tomorrow:** What does Andy Burnham's new Cabinet mean for business? POLITICO's journalists will analyse the key appointments, the policy agenda and what to expect for tech, trade, energy, financial services and U.K.-EU trade talks. Join us online tomorrow at 2 p.m. CEST. Register [here](#) .

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

One of the EU's most divisive policy questions is whether to issue eurobonds. But what are they? They're shorthand for joint debt: rather than individual member countries borrowing separately, the EU would issue bonds on international markets. This would allow countries with weaker economies to borrow at lower interest rates. Less affluent European governments have pushed for eurobonds to spread the burden of national debt more evenly across the region; frugal northern members have warned they could undermine fiscal discipline.

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4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

MIRACLE OF DUNKIRK: The once-depressed French region surrounding Dunkirk has pulled off a surprising revival , Aude van de Hove reports. Can the rest of Europe learn from its success?

NEW U.K. GOVERNMENT TAKES SHAPE: Andy Burnham set aside his friendly, folksy public image to banish from his Cabinet the closest allies of his predecessor Keir Starmer in a ruthless first act as prime minister.

JOB MOVE: European Commission foreign affairs spokesperson Anitta Hipper will be stepping back from the podium and moving to a policy role in the cabinet of Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen. Noroc!

FOOTBALL BROMANCE: U.S. President Donald Trump stood shoulder to shoulder with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney and Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum during the FIFA World Cup final. But he only had eyes for Gianni Infantino .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: High of 25C, sunny.

WINNING THE FIGHT TO SWIM (OUTDOORS): It's long been a thorn in the side of locals: the absence of an outdoor swimming pool in Brussels. And the recent heat wave was just a reminder of how the city is missing out. But that may be about to change, with a decision that has been years in the making.

The plan: The Brussels-Capital Region government has launched a project to build an outdoor swimming pool on the Abattoir food market site in Anderlecht. The pool would be built on the roof of the Manufakture building, alongside an indoor pool, and would operate in summer, according to a proposal announced by Urban Planning Secretary Ans Persons .

Wait for it: You'll have to wait a few years before taking the plunge: The opening isn't expected until 2030.

Brussels-paced decision-making: POOL IS COOL, an organization that's been campaigning for open-air swimming in Brussels, said the government has been dragging its feet. "This step would have been possible already in 2024, but the [Brussels] government crisis put everything on hold for almost two years," the organization said over the weekend .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The election of a new chair by Germany's CDU/CSU group may be shrouded in secrecy, but the name of Thorsten Frei is definitely in the mix.

London: Andy Burnham will assemble his cabinet for the first time this morning, after his brutal purge of Whitehall Starmerites .

Paris: Why the reintroduction of insecticide Acetamiprid is wreaking political havoc in France.

Washington PM: The recent deaths of three service members in the Middle East have likely upped the stakes on the vote for \$73 billion in defense spending .

AGENDA

- Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius visits Poland to sign a deal on security connectivity.
- Fisheries Commissioner Costas Kadiris visits the Portuguese islands of Madeira to meet regional government representatives.
- Democracy Commissioner Michael McGrath meets U.S. Chairman of the Federal Trade Commission Andrew Ferguson in Washington D.C.
- Belgian King Philippe, Defense Minister Theo Francken and other officials attend the commemorations for the country's national day in Brussels.
- German Chancellor Friedrich Merz receives Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev.
- Informal meeting of competitiveness ministers in Dublin.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEPs Shaffaq Mohammed and Helga Trüpel; Italian comedian-turned-politician Beppe Grillo; Equinet's Moana Genevey; former Swedish PM Stefan Löfven; Mayor of Vorey Cécile Gallien; Mick Mulvaney, former U.S. special envoy to Northern Ireland. Belgian National Day.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editor James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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